Dadieu and Muller often to ISRO facilities, and Indian scientists had several exchange programmes with the Germans. Sarabhai saw that Germany's space programme was on a downslide because of the post-war sanctions, and in it he saw a dying opportunity to collaborate with the Germans and learn from them the art and science of rocketry. Sarabhai may not have told many people why he held Dadieu too close, but I knew later that the engineer who worked on V-2 rocket that had stunned the Allies more for its audacity than accuracy could be an invaluable friend for anyone planning to make missiles.

For Sarabhai, such powerful people as Arnold Frutkin, deputy director of NASA's International Programs Office, was just a telephone call away, but the US was obviously not among those keen to see India make strides in space. Sarabhai realised this, and it might not have been incidental that Japan, another spacefarer that he reached out to was, like Germany, on 'the other side' in World War II.

Sarabhai struck a cordial relationship with Hideo Itokawa, the father of Japanese space programme. Working on Japan's Pencil rocket in the mid-1950s, Itokawa had earned the nickname Dr Rocket. Sarabhai also knew Itokawa's central role in designing the Nakajima Ki-43 Hayabus Oscar fighter during World War II. Sarabhai initiated a programme with Japan, with scientists exchanging ideas, albeit in a general way. The US had imposed sanctions on Japan, limiting its technology experiments to low thrust rockets after the war. As a restrictive inducement, the US supplied high thrust rockets to Japan, stopping it from developing its own. But Sarabhai knew the Japanese still possessed the know-how. With faith in the Japanese wisdom on onboard-control systems and the German mastery over fabrication both not allowed by the US to be put to use by those countries Sarabhai was trying to forge a deadly brotherhood.

The US was ostensibly unhappy with India cozying up to its enemies, but Sarabhai was too big for the Americans to show their displeasure in the open, especially when India maintained its posture of being an aspiring space power for peaceful purposes. Sarabhai was taking on the Americans in the American style—assertion through diplomatic deception.

It was never lost on the US though it was often glossed over in India that Sarabhai held the dual posts of the chief of the country's space programme and